Shanin, Late Marx & the Russian Road (1983)

Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels: Preface to the Second Russian edition of the Manifesto of the Communist Party[1]

The first Russian edition of the *Manifesto of the Communist Party*, translated by Bakunin, was published early in the 1860s by the *Kolokol* press.[2] At the time, the West could see no more than a literary curiosity in this, the *Russian* edition of the *Manifesto*. Such a view would be impossible today.

The limited compass of the proletarian movement in December 1847 is most clearly shown by the final section of the *Manifesto*: 'Position of the communists in relation to the various opposition parties in various countries'. Missing here are precisely Russia and the United States. It was the time when Russia constituted the last great reserve of wholesale European reaction; and when the United States was absorbing Europe's surplus proletarian forces through immigration. Both countries supplied Europe with raw materials, as well as being market-outlets for its industrial goods. Thus, in one way or another, both countries were then pillars of the existing European order.

How completely different things are today! It was precisely European immigration which fitted North America for huge-scale agricultural production, whose competition is shaking European landed property, both big and small, to its very foundations. It also enabled the United States to exploit its colossal industrial resources, with an energy and on a scale which must shortly break the industrial monopoly hitherto enjoyed by Western Europe and particularly England. Both these circumstances react in a revolutionary way upon America itself. The farmers' small and medium-size landholdings, which underpin the whole political system, are gradually succumbing to the competition of giant farms; while a massive proletariat and a fabulous concentration of capitals are developing for the first time in the industrial regions.

Now for Russia! During the 1848–49 revolution, not only European princes but also European bourgeois discovered Russian

intervention as their only deliverance from the just-awakening proletariat. The Tsar was proclaimed chief of European reaction. Today he is in Gatchina,[3] a prisoner-of-war of the revolution, and Russia forms the vanguard of revolutionary action in Europe.

The *Communist Manifesto* set out to announce the inevitably approaching dissolution of modern bourgeois property. In Russia, however, we find that the fast-blossoming capitalist swindle and newly-developing bourgeois landed property stand face to face with peasant communal ownership of the greater part of the land. This poses the question: Can the Russian *obshchina*,[4] a form, albeit heavily eroded, of the primitive communal ownership of the land, pass directly into the higher, communist form of communal ownership? Or must it first go through the same process of dissolution which marks the West's historical development?

Today there is only one possible answer. If the Russian revolution becomes the signal for proletarian revolution in the West, so that the two complement each other, then Russia's peasant communal land-ownership may serve as the point of departure for a communist development.

Karl Marx F. Engels[5]

London, 21 January 1882

Editor's Notes

1. Written at the request of P. Lavrov (see p. 174)., It was first published in Russian in the issue no. 8-9 of *Narodnaya Volya*, the People's Will clandestine journal dated 5 February 1882. First German publication in *Der Sozialdemokrat*, no. 16 (April 1882). The text has been translated by Patrick Camiller from the German original in K. Marx and F. Engels, *Werke*, Berlin, 1962, vol. 19, pp. 295-6.
2. *Kolokol* (*The Bell*), a paper of the Russian radical opposition published abroad 1857-1869 by A. Herzen (see p. 174).
3. A palace near St. Petersburg adopted for a time as the residence of Alexander III out of fear of further attacks by the People's Will.
4. I.e. Russian peasant commune, written in Russian, transliterated into Latin script by the authors.
5. The signature kept as in the original, i.e. Engels using his initial only.